

Valeriana officinalis (Valerianaceae)

Valerian

Valerian has been used as a sedative and relaxant at least since Roman times. It was known to Dioscorides in the 1st century CE, who named it *phu*, the sound of the word reflecting its unpleasant smell. Valerian helps relieve stress and has become an increasingly popular remedy in recent decades. It is a safe, nonaddictive relaxant that reduces nervous tension and anxiety and promotes restful sleep.



Valerian helps reduce stress. Its name is thought to be derived from the Latin *valere*, "to be well."

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Europe and northern Asia, valerian grows wild in damp conditions. It is cultivated in central and eastern Europe. The plant is grown from seed in spring, and the root and rhizome of 2-year-old plants are unearthed in autumn.

Related Species

V. capensis is given in South Africa for hysteria and epilepsy; *V. hardwickii*, found in China and Indonesia, is taken as an antispasmodic; *V. ulginosa* was used for cramps and menopausal symptoms by the Menominee people in North America; and *V. wallichii* is used in the Himalayas in almost exactly the same way as valerian.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (up to 1.4%), including bornyl acetate, beta-caryophyllene
- Iridoids (valepotriates)—valtrate, isovaltrate
- Alkaloids

Key Actions

- Sedative
- Relaxant
- Relieves muscle spasms
- Relieves anxiety
- Lowers blood pressure

Research■ **Therapeutic properties**

Extensive research in Germany and Switzerland has endorsed the use of valerian to aid sleep, improve sleep quality, and lower blood pressure. A German trial carried out in 2002 that tested valerian and oxazepam (a conventional sleep treatment) found both to be effective—83% of those taking valerian rated the treatment as very good compared to 73% of those taking oxazepam.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Historical uses** Known as "all-heal" in the Middle Ages, valerian was credited with many virtues, in particular with healing epilepsy. In 1592, Fabius Calumna published a detailed work on herbal medicine in which he claimed to have cured his epilepsy with the herb.

■ **Stress-related disorders**

Valerian reduces mental overactivity and nervous excitability, helping people who find it hard to "switch off." It is beneficial for almost any stress-related condition, and, in general, has a calming, rather than directly sedative, effect on the mind.

■ **Anxiety & insomnia** Many symptoms of anxiety, including tremors, panic, palpitations, and sweating, can be relieved with

**Valerian**

Erect perennial growing to 4 ft (1.2 m), with pinnate divided leaves and pink flowers.

Parts Used

Root and rhizome are harvested in autumn when they contain the highest level of active ingredients.



Dried root and rhizome

Fresh root and rhizome

Valepotriates in the rhizome and root induce sleep

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Can cause drowsiness. Do not take valerian if already taking sleep-inducing drugs.



Tablets often also contain other herbs. Take for stress or anxiety.



Powder can be taken as capsules (to make, p. 292). For insomnia, take 1–2 doses of 500 mg at night.



Tincture (to make, p. 292). For anxiety, take 20 drops in hot water up to 5 times a day.

🍵 **Decoction** (to make, p. 291). Take 1–5 tbsp as a sedative at night.

valerian. It is a useful remedy for insomnia, whether caused by anxiety or overexcitement.

■ **Effective relaxant** Valerian relaxes overcontracted muscles, and is helpful for shoulder and neck tension, asthma, colic, irritable bowel syndrome, period pain, and muscle spasms.

■ **High blood pressure** Valerian is used with other herbs in remedies

for high blood pressure caused by stress and anxiety.

Self-help Uses

- **Chronic anxiety**, p. 308.
- **Insomnia**, p. 309.
- **Nervous exhaustion**, p. 309.
- **Premenstrual syndrome**, p. 315.
- **Sleeplessness due to backache**, p. 313.